Why British urban planning should be more Croydon *(2019-2022)**

1. What did Croydon do?

excerpts from Croydon's Suburban Design Guide

CONTEMPORARY REINTERPRETATION

2.8.4 Schemes could seek to create a development that reads as contemporary whilst working with traditional character forms and/or features and materials predominant in an area. When pursuing a contemporary reinterpretation approach, it is often possible to successfully integrate contemporary details into traditional forms or traditional detailing into contemporary forms. Contemporary reinterpretation should not allow for the poor marrying of architectural styles, or poorly applied features or pastiche.



Figure 2.8b: Coombe Road - an example of a Contemporary Reinterpretation approach designed by Common Ground Architects. The massing and materials of the proposal refer to the surrounding buildings, but distinguishes itself through the folded form of the roof and contemporary detailing. The proposal delivers several new homes across two buildings.

SYMPATHETIC AND FAITHFUL

2.8.5 Schemes should closely relate to the existing surrounding typologies by pursuing a similar form, style, materials and detailing. Proposals which adopt this approach and create poor-quality copies of the characteristic architecture of an area will not be acceptable. It can be challenging to be sympathetic and faithful where a proposal departs from the predominant density or scale of buildings in the area.



Figure 2.8c: Oval Mews - an example of a Sympathetic and Faithful approach in this development by Chartwell Land & New Homes. Attention to detail in the selection of materials, choice of windows and proportions of the proposal. The new development delivers several new homes; refer section 2.44 for more details on this case study.



Figure 2.10c: Where surrounding buildings are predominantly detached dwellings of two (2) or more storeys, new developments may be three (3) storeys with an additional floor contained within the roof space or set back from the building envelope below.



Figure 2.10d: Where surrounding buildings are predominantly single storey, new development should seek to accommodate a third storey within the roof space.



Figure 2.10e: Where surrounding buildings are semi-detached homes in a planned estate, new developments should seek to accommodate a full third storey partially contained within the roof space to ensure the characteristic scale of the buildings along the street is maintained.



Figure 2.10f: The addition of a third storey within terraced houses will only generally only be through accommodation within the roof. The acceptability of this will be based on the merit of design and the impact on street scene, given the consistent nature of continuous eaves and roof heights. A terraced house on a corner plot may seek to provide a full additional storey.

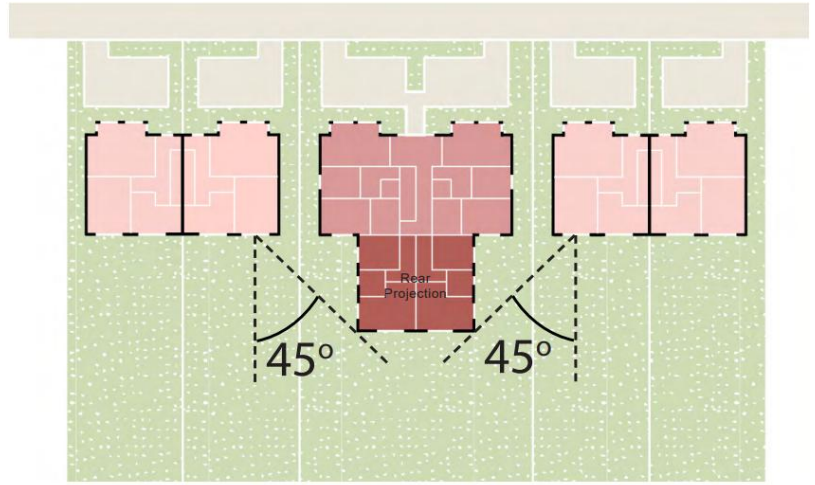


Figure 2.11b: Depth of projection no greater than 45 degrees as measured from the middle of the window of the closest ground floor habitable room on the rear wall of the main neighbouring property on both sides.

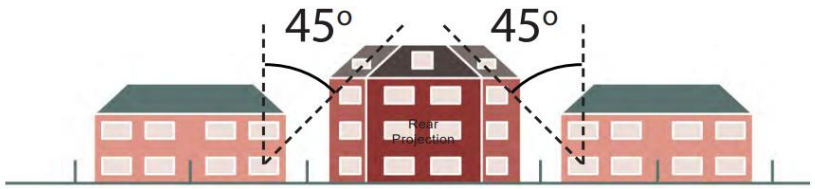
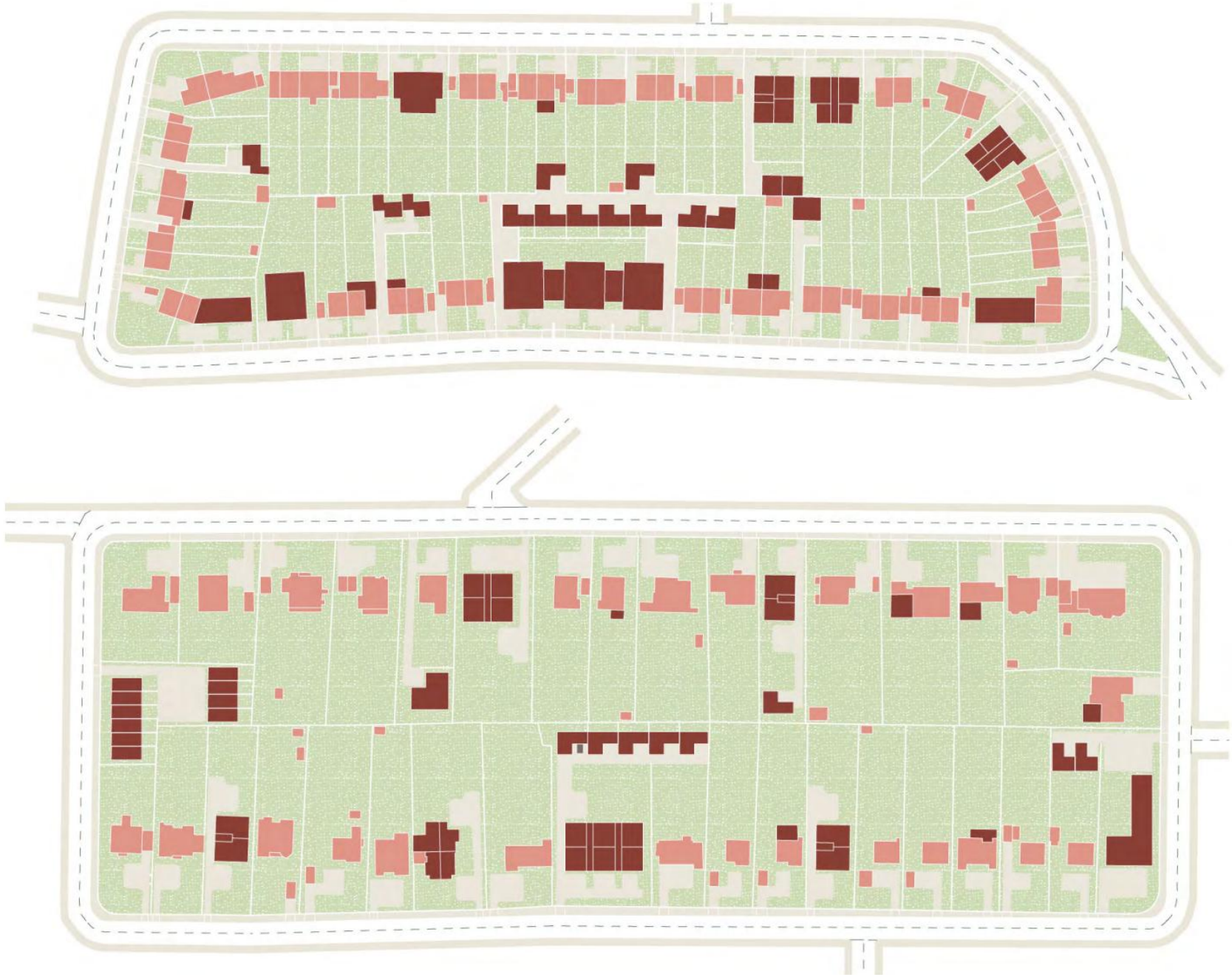
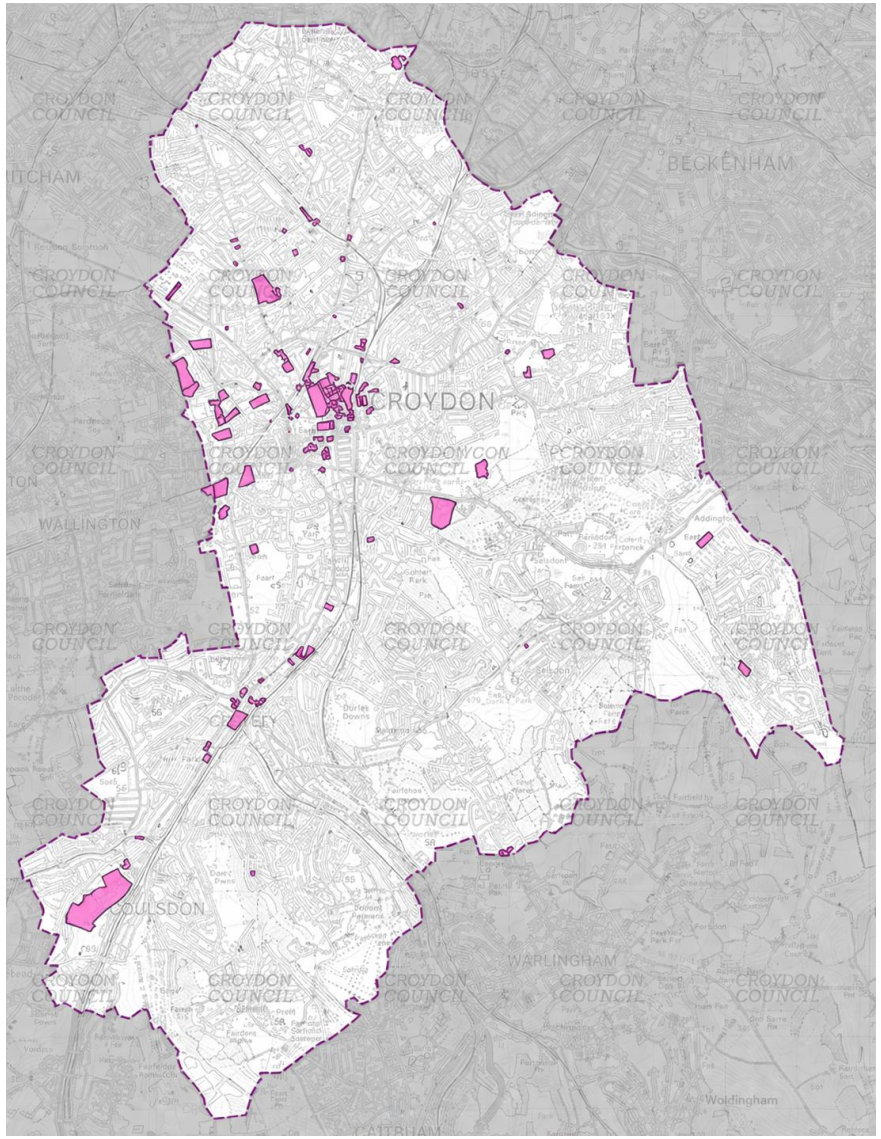


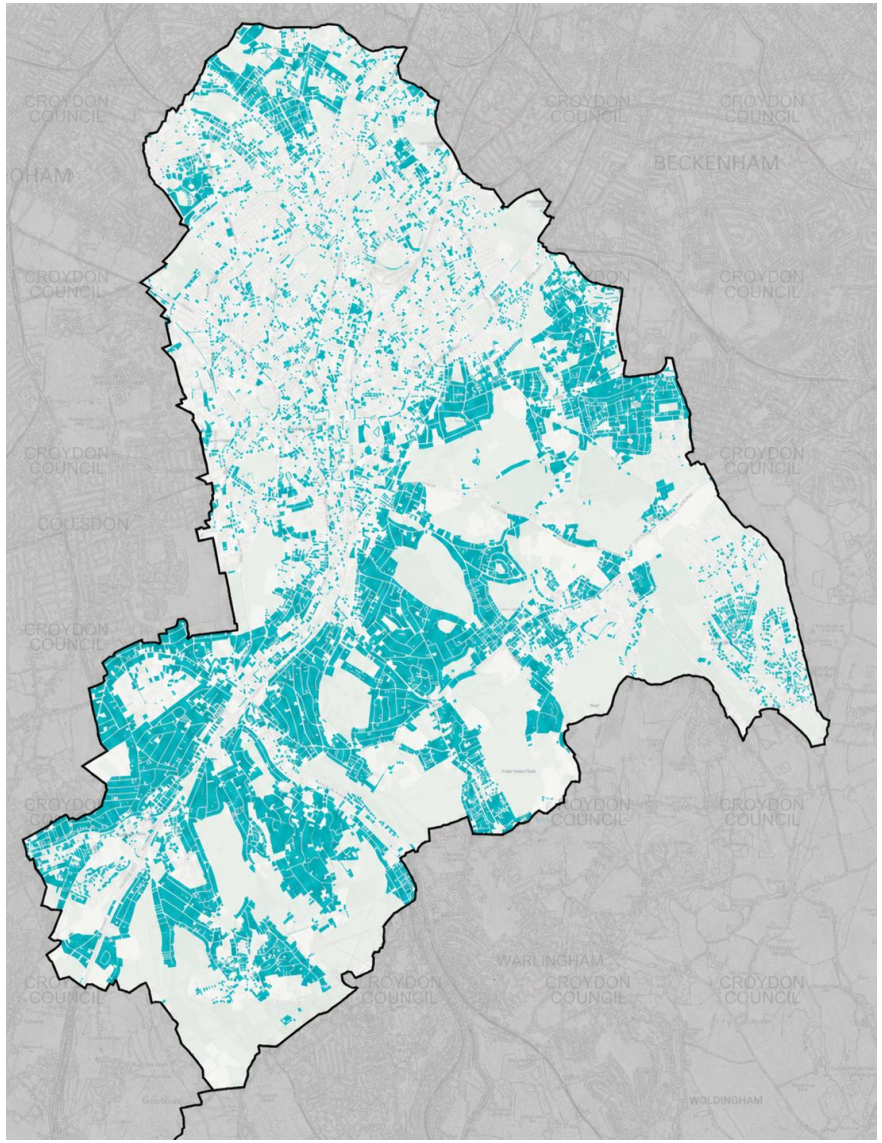
Figure 2.11c: Height of projection beyond the rear of neighbouring properties is no greater than 45 degrees as measured from the middle of the window of the closest ground floor habitable room on the rear wall of the main neighbouring property on both sides.



Development land directly allocated for housing in Croydon's local plan



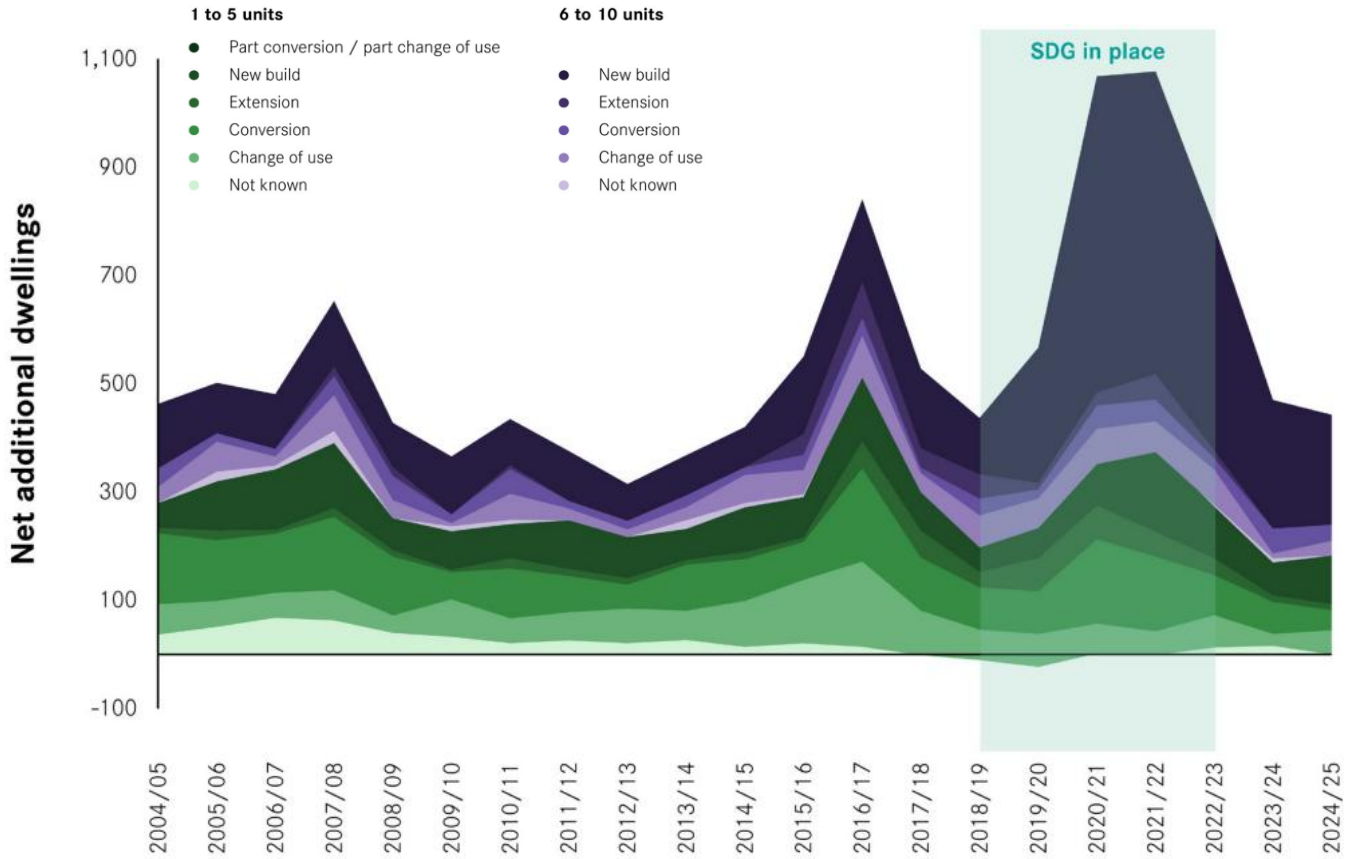
Land made developable by the Suburban Design Guide



2. What happened?

Croydon delivered over 1000 homes per year on small sites, when the policy was in place

Net additional dwellings in Croydon on small sites, by site size and development type, 2004-2024



Source: Greater London Authority



2 3-bed flats
4 2-bed flats
3 1-bed flats

1 house

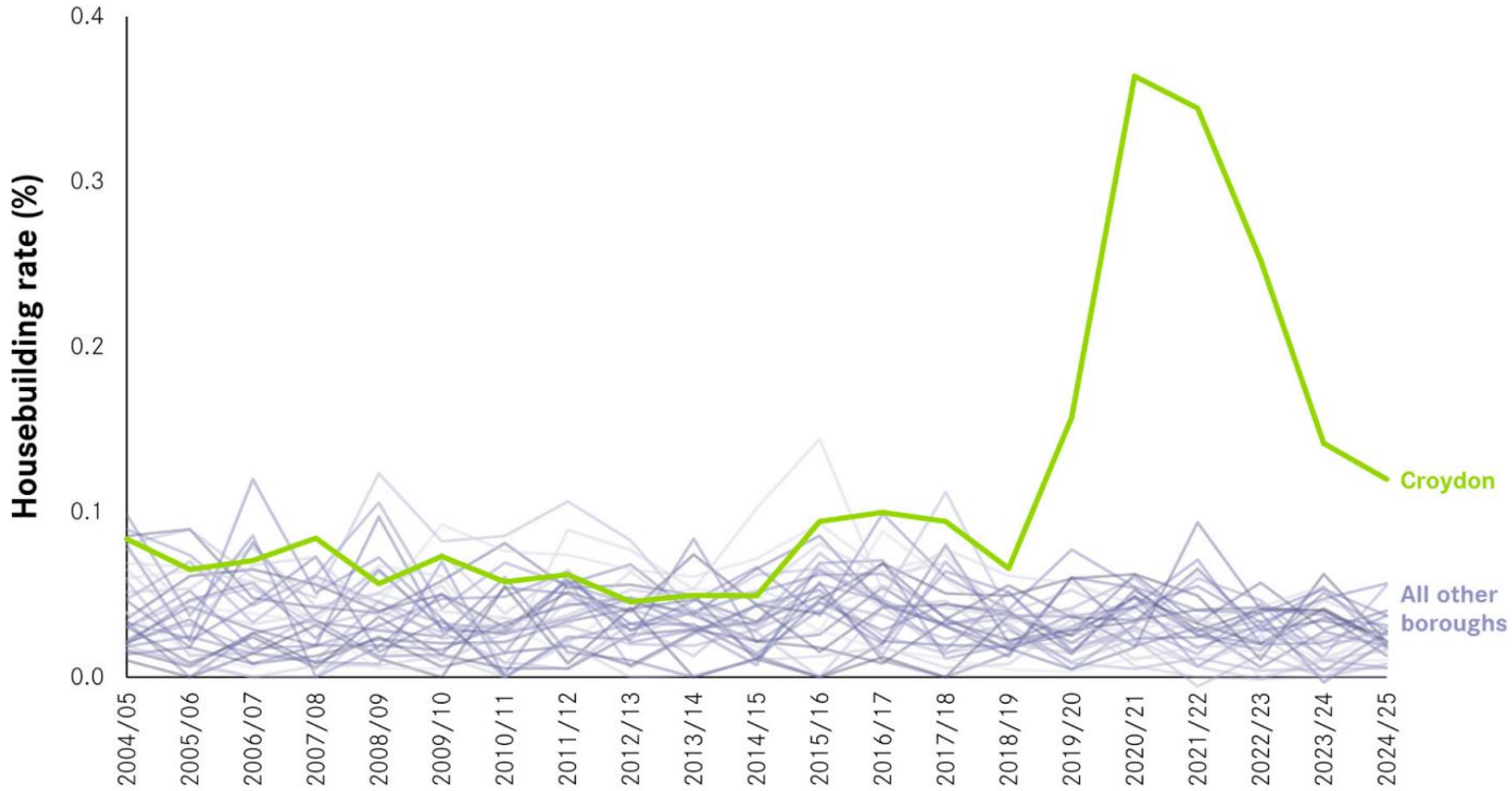


4 3-bed flats
2 2-bed flats
3 1-bed flats

1 house

Small site redevelopment was never a thing. Until it was…

Housebuilding rate on new build 6-10 unit sites, London boroughs, 2004-2024



Source: Greater London Authority

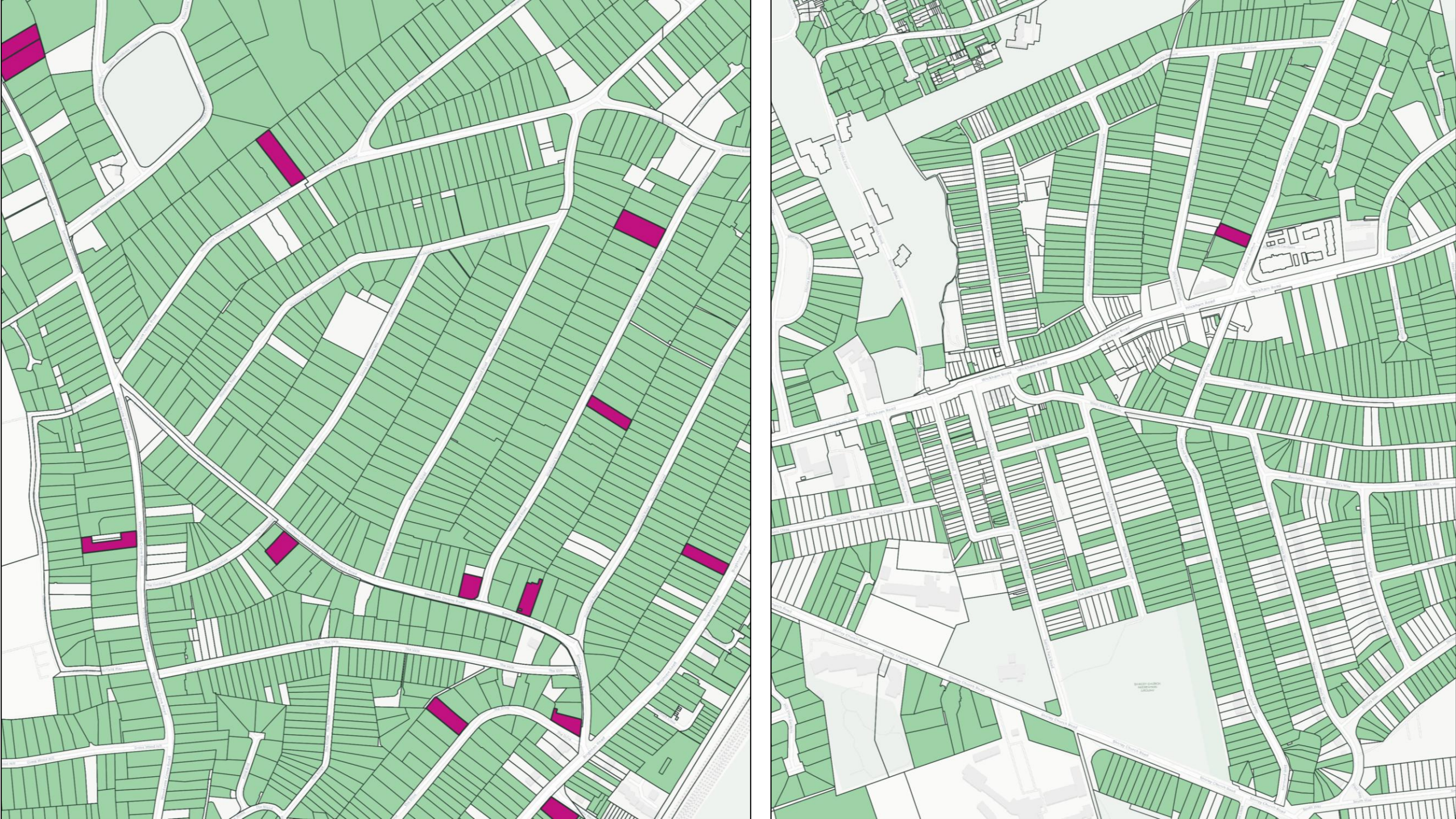
3. Why did this work in Croydon?

Observed land costs and gross development value, modelled build costs, and profit, average 6-10 unit development in Croydon, 2019-2023



Sources: Land Registry; Centre for Cities modelling. See Appendix 1 for all data sources.

Small-scale redevelopment in Croydon was highly profitable

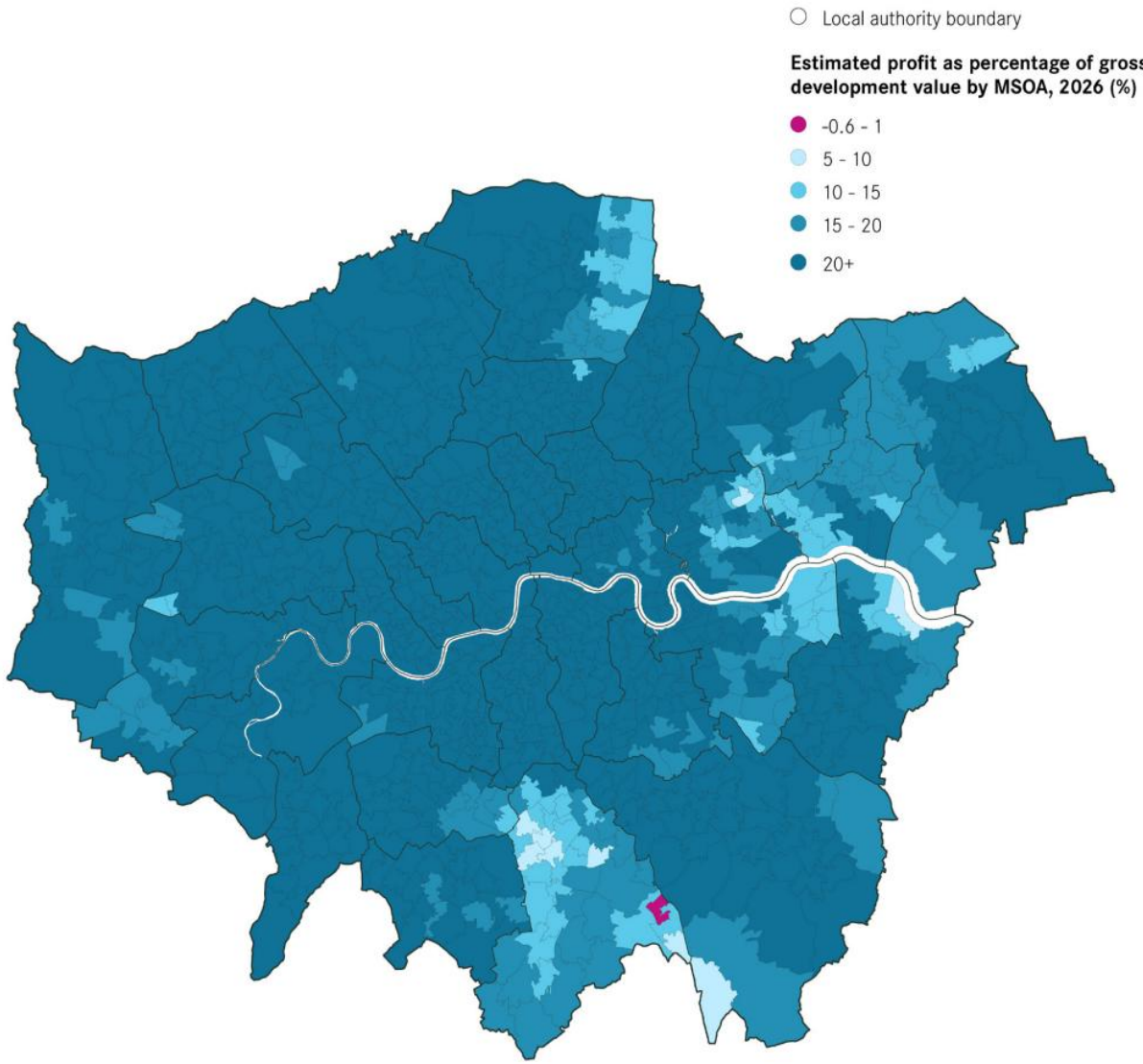


Only 0.2% of suitable plots were redeveloped each year

If building continued at this rate until 2100,
over ¾ of detached houses would remain

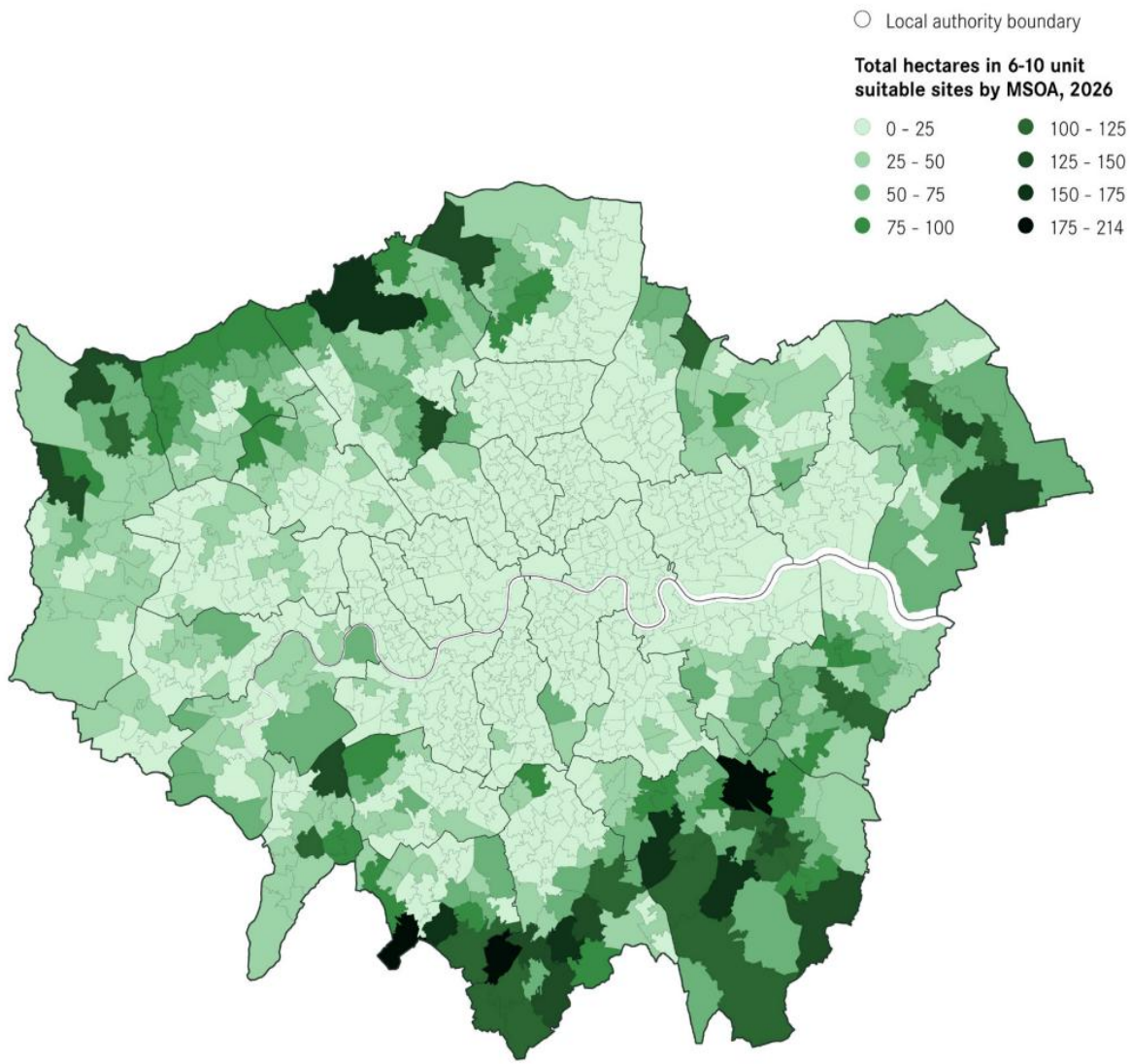
4. What would happen if Croydon's policy was re-introduced across London today?

SDG-style redevelopment is viable almost everywhere in London

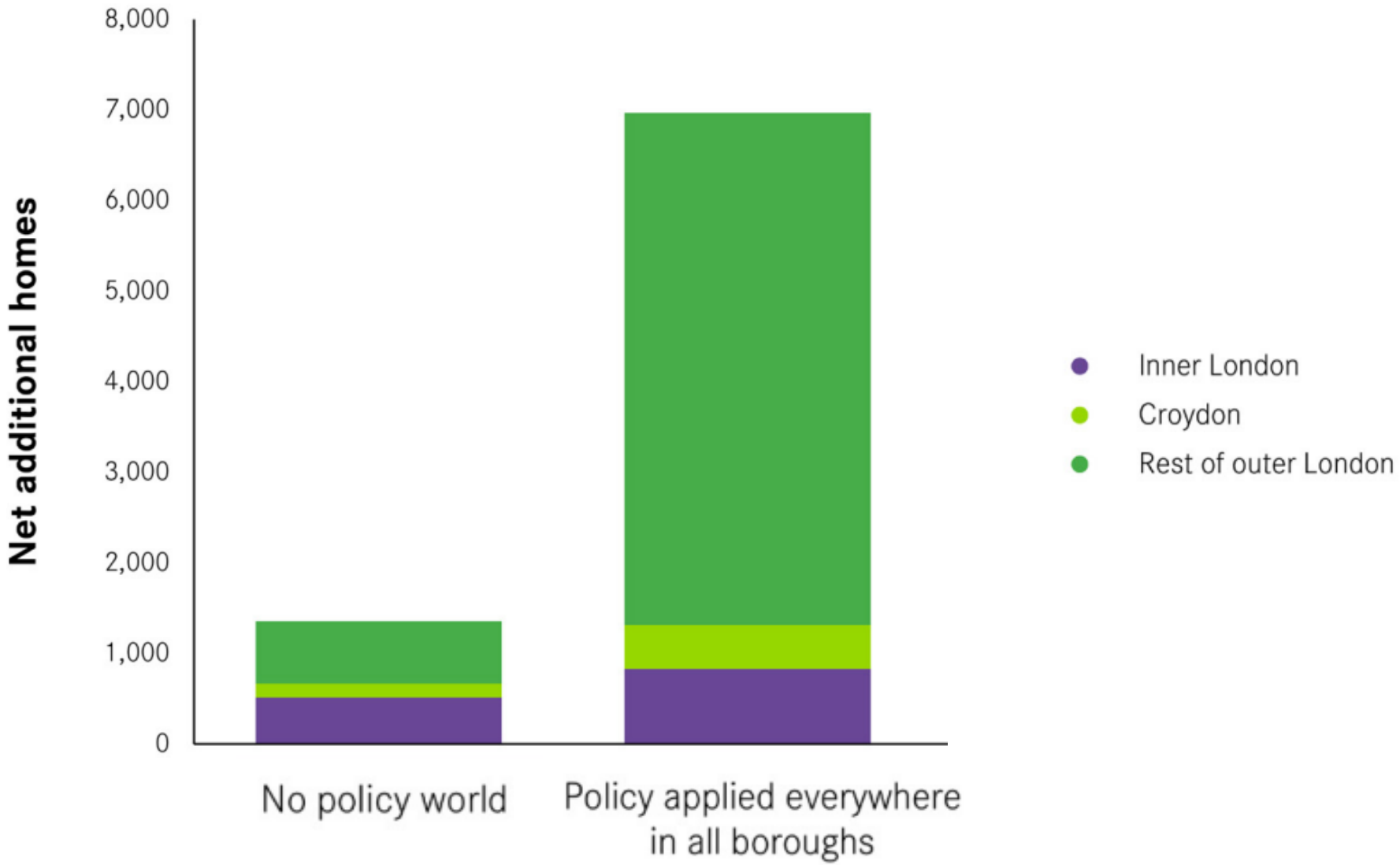


Sources: Centre for Cities modelling. See Appendix 1 for all data sources.

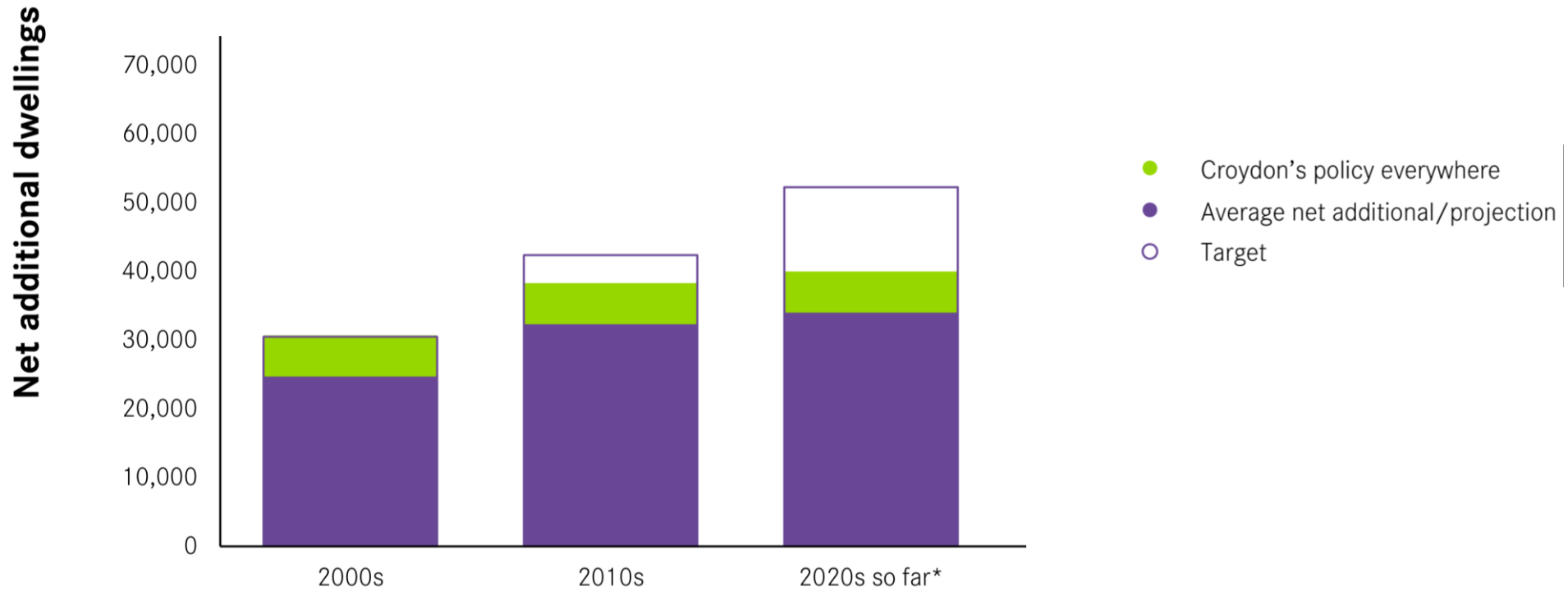
Most land on sites suitable for small scale redevelopment is in Outer London



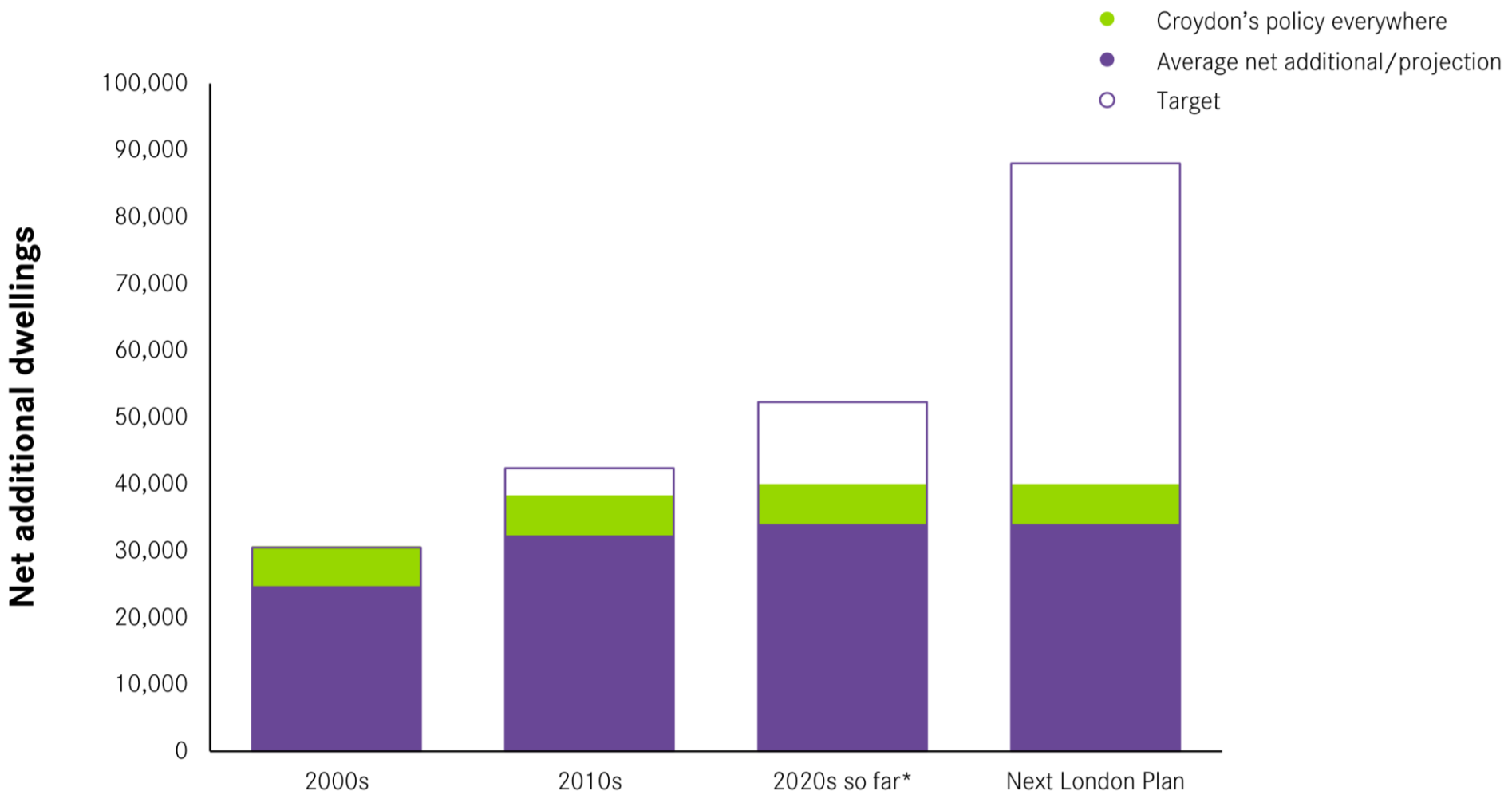
Sources: INSPIRE; Centre for Cities modelling. See Appendix 1 for all data sources.


Net additional homes
8,000
7,000
6,000
5,000
4,000
3,000
2,000
1,000
0
No policy world
Policy applied everywhere in all boroughs
Inner London
Croydon
Rest of outer London

London has struggled to meet its housebuilding targets for decades



London will need to pull every lever it can to meet its new mega target



Sorry I didn’t have time to talk about

- Why the policy only lasted 3 years in Croydon
- What a similar policy might look like in other boroughs
- How similar policies could be durably rolled out across London
- Whether similar policies would work in other cities

… time for questions